THE ALCHEMY OF SLOW COOKING

For **Chef Nitin Mathur,** the Executive Chef at Taj Palace, New Delhi, a kitchen is more than a workspace; it is a meticulously choreographed stage. Steering the culinary narrative at Loya, the hotel's flagship North Indian destination, Mathur brings 32 years of Taj legacy to the beautifully laid out table.

ANATOMY OF A CRAFT KITCHEN

We found that the kitchen at Loya is a blend of high-tech efficiency and primordial heat, designed with distinct zones that cater to specific culinary disciplines. It features a dedicated curry section and a high energy live kitchen where the drama unfolds in full view of the diners. "We have a live kitchen, which denotes sigri, tandoor, a tawa and the pots where slow cooking happens, which is visible from the restaurant," shares Mathur.

BOTTOM'S UP

When discussing essential equipment, Mathur bypasses flashy modern gadgets in favour of the humble heavy-bottomed pan. He explains that the quality of the brass or metal vessel matters most because a thick base acts as a natural heat regulator. "The heavier the bottom of the pan the more evenly and slowly it heats, instead of buring the food," he explains, adding that the, "Quality of the pan and the pot what you are cooking matters the most."

GEOMETRY OF A DREAM KITCHEN

For the professional and the home enthusiast alike, Mathur's vision of a dream kitchen centres on ergonomics and environmental comfort. He envisions a space where movement is minimised and everything is within arm's reach. "Moreover, modern kitchens have shifted away from being stuffy," he says, highlighting the importance of superior exhaust and HVAC systems.

Mathur's final advice for home cooks is to look past the overwhelming number of internet recipes and focus on the why behind the techniques. He points out that understanding the specific role of an ingredient is what truly defines a dish. "If you understand the dishes, it is easier to go because the recipe will always say sauté the onions, but you need to know how much."

" TO UNDERSTAND THE FOOD, YOU NEED TO UNDERSTAND THE RECIPE, AS WELL AS THE REGIONAL SPECIALTIES, BY EATING WITH THAT REGION'S PEOPLE. SOMETIMES RECIPES AREN'T ENOUGH." **— CHEF NITIN MATHUR**



